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WR121, 10:30-12:20
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WR121 Reflection

My interest was piqued when Mr. Couch informed the class, "I am not going to… [teach] any of you how to write… my job these next ten weeks is to teach you how to *rewrite* [emphasis added]" (Couch 31:27-31:52). I thought it was odd that a writing teacher wouldn't be teaching me how to write. But odd things appeal to me. I looked forward to the challenges this teaching style might present and wondered how I might rise to meet them. Well, ten weeks, thirty drafts, and 6,000+ words later, I have written, and I have *rewritten*, but I cannot say that I learned how to *rewrite*. Foolish writing teacher! What I have learned instead is much more valuable, and that is to *reimagine* my writing.

I know something of the work it takes to write a college essay from writing a research paper. I began, as instructed, by selecting a topic about which I had no opinion: active-shooter drills. I wanted to find out whether these drills affected child development. My plan was to use what I had learned in my psychology class – Piaget's stages of cognitive development and neuronal development – to answer this question. But that is not where I ended up. After five or six hours of browsing articles from databases and popular sources like *The New York Times*, and *Washington Post*, I stumbled onto a conversation about safety, spending, emotional trauma, and rarity. This seemed to be a more interesting topic, even if the process to uncover it was time consuming. The properties tab of the word document I used to organize my sources indicates I spent twelve-hours and twenty-nine minutes summarizing and editing my sources. Fortunately, it was time well spent because I found exactly what I was looking for: the best available evidence. All that remained was to put it on paper.

Nearly a month into the process of writing and rewriting, I had a carefully constructed six-and-a-half-page essay that evinced its claims and arrived at a conclusion containing the best available answer. Feeling confident, I submitted my paper for peer review. For good measure, I also submitted it to the writing lab. Both returned favorable reviews, pointing out only minor errors which took little time to address. After a little bit of polishing, I felt triumphant. All I had to do was kick my feet up and profit. I was taking a ride on the much-vaunted gravy train and the next stop was an A+… or so I thought.

A week after my moment of triumph, I was tasked with reading chapter ten, "Earn Your Credibility," from *The Humble Argument*. Under the subheading "Understand Your Readers," author Roy K. Humble wrote something that completely changed my perspective, "You have to put yourself in [the reader's] position, looking back at you and your questionable credibility" (173). My paper ultimately concluded that active-shooter drills should be ended because they were nothing more than a money grab. What I had not fully appreciated was the results the drills offered, nor had I properly acknowledged that parents might be receptive to those results. Here I was confidently offering advice that a critical reader might see as dismissive. I was floored. With that one sentence, the biscuit-wheels fell off the gravy train and I was back to work editing. I ended up deleting three paragraphs, adding another, and rewriting both my intro and conclusion. Funny how a simple sentence inspired so much work. Just one more thing to think about as I consider how this class has changed the way I write.

Reflecting on my time in this class, I see now that improving my writing is a process. I do not get everything right on the first attempt. Even when I feel like I have written something truly amazing, I accept that it may need to be rewritten. I regret that some of it may even need to be deleted. But these are not losses, they are opportunities to try something new, like taking on

another viewpoint or moving around paragraphs for better flow. I have even explored changing the location of topic sentences to either the middle or the end of a paragraph, which is something I have never done before. Another thing I learned is how to employ deduction, something Humble taught me in chapter nine of *The Humble Argument*. I call it the Gwen Stefani approach to the writing process because it requires making a claim, providing evidence, with an assumption that leaves No Doubt, Underneath it All (149-151). Referencing songs from more than twenty years in the past is yet another process I have come to embrace, one that I hope makes my writing better.

Before this class, I believed my role as the writer was to generate a report, add some commentary, then wrap it all up with a nice summary. More fool me! I have since learned that writing is not about convincing the reader that I am right; writing is about finding that which the reader needs to know, presenting it honestly, and in a way that respects both their perspective and intelligence. By the time they get to my conclusion, I want my reader to feel heard. More importantly, I see my job as the writer to improve my reader's situation in some way, be it getting a laugh, or imparting some sage advice. Learning this required reflection. Putting it into action required no small amount of effort. And it resulted in something more than a report with a cute little summary at the end.

Where I ended up in this class is not how I approached it. Ten weeks ago, I would have started an assignment by imagining where I wanted to end up, then work my way backward. Today, I am humbled. I see that my approach was foolish. Making a claim about what should be done restricts the choices available to my reader. If I am asking my reader to cede their decision making to my reasoning, I must do so responsibly. Going forward, I will reconsider my role in the reader-writer relationship by making more considerate, and better evinced claims. I am only

capable of doing this because the last ten weeks have pushed me to reimagine my approach to writing. Maybe my writing teacher isn't so foolish after all.

Works Cited

Couch, Daniel. *W22 WR121-RM 50163 – Academic Composition*. 5 Jan. 2022. Chemeketa Community College, Zoom lecture. *Zoom Cloud Recordings*, https://chemeketa.zoom.us/rec/play/OBfRAU8RqgDS1-dwF9mDN_CnaemflIwKWhND1o5mAdFcPqLW-EZ40ZXEqkVykaK-czv_o2oGnU6cFH_M.NW2sNqg9UIyvpnwz. Accessed 9 Mar. 2022.

Humble, Roy K. *The Humble Argument: A Readable Introduction to Argument and the College Essay*. Unaspiring Writer, Edition 1.2 (July 2019).